



Berklee Online

Songwriting & Producing Music

Digital Handbook



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Welcome!

Whether you're looking to jumpstart your career, realize your artistic aspirations, or connect with a musical community, we're excited for you to study with us! Check out the lessons and features in this handbook, and learn how Berklee Online can help you pursue your passion and build your musical future.

All the best,

A stylized, handwritten signature in white ink, likely belonging to Sean Hagon, set against the dark blue background.

Sean Hagon

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Making Your Melody Work

By Jimmy Kachulis

From the Online Course
Songwriting: Melody

Melody is one of the most important and immediate aspects of a song. It's the element that the audience sings along with. It's the thing that most intimately brings out the emotion of the lyric story. The melody also exists alongside and on top of the harmony. But that relationship can differ depending on the effect you are trying to achieve with your song.

When we're setting our lyrics together with the melody, there are three considerations we need to make:

- ① What is the length of each note?
- ② What is the length of the phrases?
- ③ What is the space between the phrases?

These may seem like trivial questions, but the note length, phrase length, and phrase space will determine how your lyrics feel to the listener. Let's start with the notes. Listen to Bob Marley's "No Woman, No Cry." You'll find that the verses—which are conversational in tone, and build the story of the track—generally

have shorter notes. The chorus, where the title of the track is repeated, consists of longer notes. This is no accident. When lyrics are set to longer notes, they are emphasized and are automatically more dramatic.

The melodic phrases you use for your lyric sections can be of a standard or surprising length. Standard two- and four-bar phrases will give a song a steady feel. Surprising phrases—any other bar length—will keep things fresh and draw the listeners' attention. Good songs will have a mixture of both. And those phrases will gain additional power from the spaces in between them. Verses will benefit from having lyrics be more closely packed together with little room to breathe. Choruses, on the other hand, benefit from being drawn out and require more space between the lyrics as a result. Once you have the basic lyrical ideas in place for your melody, try developing them with some repetition or present new ideas as a contrast.

While setting the lyrics to your melody is important, it is the interaction between melody and harmony that will define your song. Let's say we already have a harmony in place, or we have a way in mind that we want our melody to work so we're not thinking

of melodic ideas with no context. So let's develop a pitch. When it comes to the pitch of a melody, there are three approaches:

- ① **Melody On Chords**—Where the melody stays on a chord
- ② **Melody Over Chords**—Where the melody is in the key, but is only loosely related to the chords
- ③ **Melody Against a Bass Line** (Counterpoint)—Where there are two melodies and the vocal melody moves against a bass melody

No matter what approach you take, you're going to start on one of the tones in the chord. Starting from the tones will allow you to build a compelling melody consisting of even the simplest materials and development. The example that comes to mind is Billy Joel's "We Didn't Start the Fire," a song whose melody would resemble a straight line if mapped out. If you want to decorate a melodic line like this (and you might, considering how flat it could sound), you can zig-zag between the neighboring notes that reside right above and below your original tone. However many chord tones you try to base your melody on, know that each will have an effect, creating a

distinct melodic shape. When we think of melodies, several terms will help us imagine what the notes look (and sound) like.

- **Stationary**—A straight line
- **Zig-zag**—Decorates a straight line with a neighbor
- **Ascending**—Starts low and goes up
- **Descending**—Starts high and goes down
- **Arch**—Starts low, goes up and then down
- **Inverted Arch**—Starts high, goes down and then back up

But say you really want to spice things up with your melody. Counterpoint between a bass line melody moving against the vocal melody might do the trick. But not all bass lines are built equal. The easiest way to determine if the bass melody would make for good counterpoint is if it could be sung. Bass lines that move all over the staff will be useless unless you're going to be scat singing. There are four kinds of standard counterpoint: **parallel**, **similar**, **oblique**, and **contrary**. If a bass line has the same melodic shape as the vocal line, then it is a form of parallel counterpoint. Similar counterpoint features a bass line and vocal melody that move in essentially the

same direction, though not as closely as parallel. Now here's where things get interesting; oblique counterpoint will have either the bass or vocal line revolve around a limited number of notes. The bass line might stay on one note or move around in an ostinato. The vocal line will stay in basically the same place. If you've heard the opening verse of "Stairway to Heaven" then you've heard oblique counterpoint. Finally, contrary counterpoint, as its name implies, has the bass and vocal lines moving in opposite directions.

These are just some of the basics of melodic development, but the simplest methods of developing melody are tools you'll be using for the rest of your songwriting career.

Jimmy Kachulis is the author of the Berklee Online course from which this lesson comes. See what song first got him into songwriting on the following pages, or learn more about the other lessons in this course by clicking the link below.

Want to explore this course even further?

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Instructor Spotlight:

Jimmy Kachulis

Jimmy Kachulis is a professor of songwriting and lyric writing at Berklee. An accomplished composer, arranger, and conductor, he has worked with artists such as George Coleman, Jon Hendricks, John Lewis, and Martha Reeves, and his compositions have been featured on scores from *The Sopranos* to *Touched By An Angel*.

At Berklee Online, Jimmy authored the courses *Songwriting: Harmony*, *Songwriting: Melody*, and *Songwriting: Writing Hit Songs*.

What does performing a well-written song do for you?

It shows me that an effective song can be done by a number of artists, in a variety of styles—and it still comes across. Often a different performance/production will reveal an aspect of the song I never heard before.

What song first alerted you to genius songwriting skills?

“The Tracks of My Tears” by Smokey Robinson.

What do you look for in a songwriting collaborator?

Someone who has complementary skills, is fun to hang with, open to ideas, and remains positive in assessing my ideas, even when they want to change them.

Can a person be taught to be a good songwriter?

I’ve taught thousands of songwriters and the one constant I can attest to is: when we practice we get better—write, write, write!

Which is more important, the singer or the song?

Both are important for a great recording/performance. When these three are present: a great song, a great performance, a great arrangement/production, the magic happens.



Instructor Insights

Peter Bell's Tips for Advertising Music

By Berklee Online

Peter Bell knew that he made it in the music biz when he heard people singing his jingle on the subway in Boston. It was a commercial spot that he co-wrote for a local bank, and featured the Dorchester neighborhood native boy band: New Kids on the

Block. The synth-soaked jingle advertised the bank's new ATM card (a novel product at the time), ending with the band's catchy and quotable exclamation, *What are you waiting for? Get your BayBank card!* Bell says that New Kids, then on their ascent to fame, were excited to contribute their vocals to a Boston establishment.

“One thing that happens as you practice this profession is that you build a contact list of other talented people that you can draw on,” says Bell. “That’s a wonderful part of the job. It’s so much fun to work with talented people who almost uniformly are glad to come into the studio and work on these small form pieces of music—30 seconds, 60 seconds. They put their heart and soul into it.”

Bell is a two-time Emmy-winner and author of the Berklee Online course, *Writing and Producing Advertising Music*. He has composed music spots for shows like *This Old House* and *New Yankee Workshop*, and has written countless jingles for brands like Nike, RC Cola, Converse, and the American Red Cross. In addition to the advertising side of the music industry, his guitar performance credits include Bonnie Raitt, Susan Tedeschi, and James Montgomery. He has also has produced tracks featuring Tracey Bonham, Livingston Taylor, Layla Hathaway, Patty Griffin, and others.

Bell says there are five major things you need to consider if you're looking to explore writing and producing music for advertising.

Create Music Outside of Your Comfort Zone

When you start writing music for advertising, you'll find that your clients will request music spots in a style or genre outside of your familiarity. This will help you become a more versatile musician and will also give you the opportunity to collaborate with other musicians with specializations.

“You're the music expert and your clients will assume that you can be all things to all people,” says Bell. “So if they want Elizabethan music, or if they want world music, or if they want New Orleans funk music, they'll come to you and expect you to do the rest. So one of the skills you develop is to be able to analyze the music and produce in that style. Another important skill is to develop a contact list where you can involve other practitioners who are experts in particular styles.”

Build Your Credibility

Bell says that you can start building your portfolio by doing a few initial projects pro bono. He recommends going to a local business that is already on the air and ask them if they would like a custom-made jingle. Just request that they cover your expenses like recording or hiring musicians. If they put it on the air, then you have some name recognition to help you secure more jobs.

“Then you have proof of concept and you can go to an ad agency and say, ‘Have you heard the so-and-so car dealership ad that’s running right now? Well, I did that.’ And that is a door-opener,” he says.

Prepare for Success

Just like the rest of the music industry, writing music for advertising is competitive and hard to break into. Bell says that while you can’t control where your opportunities are going to come from, you can be ready when an opportunity does present itself.

“No matter what age or what level you’re at, you can work on your own development and prepare for that moment,” says Bell. “I always

analogize it to standing next to a brick wall, and there are no doors and all of a sudden you don't know why or when, but a door opens. You want to be ready to walk through if and when it does. That's empowering, I think."

Set up Your Studio with These Seven Essentials

Times have changed since Bell initially set up his recording studio, after taking out a loan for tens of thousands of dollars. Now we're in what he calls the golden age of production, where you can set up your own studio for a few thousand dollars with these seven items:

- Computer
- Software
- MIDI Controller
- Audio Interface
- Microphone
- Headphones
- Audio Monitors

"The means of production are now available to the proletariat," says Bell. "Just about anybody can scrape together a few thousand dollars

eventually in order to get up a small production studio and then you're ready to roll."

Know That You're Solving a Problem

When you're first starting out writing music for advertising, you want to present yourself as someone who is experienced and capable of getting the job done. It's easy to feel like a client is doing you a favor by hiring you, but it's important to remember that you're solving a problem for them.

"I would say to someone starting out, remember that you're not calling to ask for a favor; You're calling to partner with them," says Bell. "You're calling to offer them a valuable asset. So you don't want to get confused about what's going on here. You want to partner with them with a common goal."



Instructor Spotlight:

Chrissy Tignor

Chrissy Tignor is a producer, songwriter, recording engineer, and vocalist. She is a professor in the Contemporary Writing and Production Department at Berklee, and is a co-founder of the Songwriting and Producing Music major. Her music has been synced on Discovery Channel and TLC, and she currently works under the pseudonym Data Child.

She has authored several courses in songwriting and production, including *Producing Songwriting Demos with Pro Tools* and *Logic*.

When did you first get the idea to put together a program that combines production with songwriting?

Many songwriters have to rely on producers to help realize their ideas, and I firmly believe that any songwriter can learn how to use a DAW and take control of their creative vision. A basic understanding of music technology and how to use it opens up many doors for songwriters, both creatively and professionally.

What's a piece of songwriting advice you've held onto throughout your career?

The best piece of songwriting advice I ever received was to always have healthy collaborations. I used to be scared of advocating for myself and my intellectual property, but now I don't enter a creative collaboration without the initial discussion of splits/rights first. If someone doesn't want to have an open, healthy conversation about making sure everyone is happy in a collab, that's a big red flag.

Same question, but with music production . . .

Never tune a vocal in front of the singer. Seriously, listen to this advice and send your singers out for a coffee when you open Melodyne and thank me later.

How to Get the Most Out of Your Mixes

By Rich Mendelson and Alejandro Rodriguez

From the Online Course
Art of Mixing

Sound mixing is a combination of art and technology with the end goal of creating a new sonic reality. A good mix is not good enough if only the technical aspects are taken into consideration; it must also transmit a song's message and enhance its emotions. A mixing engineer toes this line carefully, always putting the musical aspects first and foremost, while applying their technical skills, deep knowledge of processing gear, and interpretation of visual levels to accomplish an artistic result.

Below are some of the basics of mixing music, including its history, sound mixing techniques, and the various responsibilities of a mixing engineer.

What is Sound Mixing?

If we need to define sound mixing with a single word, that word would be *balance*. Mixing involves combining all the sounds received from the multitrack recording and balancing them in levels, making some louder than others. At the same time, a mixing engineer will balance them in terms of panning, placing them in the stereo field: left, center, right, or anywhere in between. They will also balance frequencies, brightening some sounds, darkening others, taking

some frequencies away, and using depth as another balance tool, to give the listener a sense of closeness or distance of a sound in a space.

A Brief History of Sound Mixing

The music industry has evolved immensely since it began more than a century ago. The origins of music recording involved a single step: musicians surrounding a horn, playing and singing as loud as they could, and mixing themselves by way of distance to the horn. Technology evolved from recording to a cylinder to recording to a disk, then to tape, from mono to stereo, then multitrack. Here are a few notable points of evolution in the world of music mixing.

Multitrack Recording

Multitrack recording means not all the musicians need to be playing at the same time. It also allows the addition of more lines, such as more guitars playing, or more voices in a chorus, more violins in the string section, and fixing mistakes of individual performers instead of the whole band. Back in the '60s, mixing engineers dealt with

few tracks and big consoles. Now, they mix several tracks—it could be more than 100—of different sounds in a music performance, either trying to recreate the original or intended musical balance, or creating something new.

Digital Audio Workstations (DAWs)

Today, it's most common for all of this to occur inside a computer, in the digital domain, using a DAW, instead of the “old-fashioned way,” using multitrack tape machines and analog consoles. A modern DAW will contain the equivalent of one or more multitrack tape machines, a host of outboard processing gear, an assortment of synthesizers and other virtual instruments, and a big, powerful mixing console, capable of various sound processing jobs plus automating almost every task—not to mention the capability of recalling instantaneously all settings from any mix. No wonder DAWs have become the standard mixing platform (though the “analog vs. digital” sound quality debate continues).

Access to Information

These days, information about music mixing is everywhere. If you want another perspective on guitar levels or drum panning, it's just

a Google search away. If you want to “test drive” a software plug-in for your DAW, there’s probably a YouTube review out there. If you want a more in-depth learning experience, you could enroll in a Berklee Online program (wink, wink).

Mixing Techniques

Now that we know a bit about what music mixing is and have general sense of its history, let’s get into some techniques and considerations that can be beneficial to the art of mixing.

Level Adjustment

Level balance is the first thing that comes to mind when mixing. We are talking about relative loudness of sounds to one another.

Featured Sounds and Details

Does a certain musical event, such as a guitar lick or a sample, create an interesting musical result that should be featured or downplayed? Certain music genres have specific common practices as to what is heard more prominently and what is considered a “color” detail.

Panning

Panning refers to the placement of sounds in the stereo field, between left and right, and anywhere in between, including center. In order to work on panning, you first must have a multichannel reproduction system. Two of the most common types are: surround and stereo. Surround is mostly used in video-related sound work, while a pure music mix is still done more often in stereo, since it is more often consumed in stereo than it is in surround.

Surround

Surround refers to a recording and playback system, which reproduces music and sounds in general coming from the front and back of the listener. There have been different attempts to establish a standard of listening in surround for decades. The most common format used nowadays is known as 5.1, which means there will be five channels plus a special one (therefore the system needs six speakers to reproduce the recording).

The six channels are grouped like this: Left, Center, Right, Surround-L, and Surround-R, plus a special channel named LFE.

The first three are obvious. The last three need to be clarified. Surround-L and Surround-R are the speakers placed left and right, behind the listener. The LFE is a sixth channel only playing very low frequencies. The name LFE comes from its use in movie theaters, as a Low Frequency Effects channel.

Stereo

Stereo means reproduction of a sound image using two channels, left and right—those channels being reproduced through speakers or headphones. This stereo imaging creates the illusion of sounds coming from anywhere between the left and right speakers, with a perfect phantom image in the center when the same signal, same level is present on both sides. Some songs use really drastic tactics with their stereo mixes: try isolating the left and right channels on the following songs to hear what we're talking about:

- “Drive My Car” by the Beatles
- “Satisfaction” by the Rolling Stones
- “Blitzkrieg Bop” by Ramones

Muting Techniques

Sound mixing also includes the knowledge—or the hunch—of what can be taken out of the mix. This could include obvious examples, like any unwanted noise, to more creative decisions about whether to use a particular instrument at all, or at least on some portions of the song, even though it was originally recorded there. Just because you recorded something doesn't mean it has to go in the mix. Bruce Springsteen's "Born to Run" originally had female backing vocals on the prechorus and chorus. The Grateful Dead's "Ripple" originally had mandolin throughout the entire song! Here are some other examples of what to mute:

Noise

From an electric guitar track, every time the guitar is not playing. Leakage from headphones or any other sounds on the strings or background vocal tracks. You can see a trend here. Any noise. In one track or in multiple tracks, only once or many times, depending on the recording. Is that a rule? Not necessarily, because sometimes leaving breathing or some other natural noises from the singer or performer makes it more intimate, up front, more human.

Building up an Arrangement

Having a structure where all instruments play all the time could be a little bit boring. Try muting some of them on the first verse, then adding some on the second, then some more on the chorus, having a second chorus with more instruments than the first, etc.

Breaking Down a Moment of the Song

Similar to the above, but this time, instead of adding tracks (instruments) as the song progresses by muting at the beginning and gradually unmuting as the song continues, you can temporarily mute a big group of tracks after they have been playing for a while in order to create a breakdown, which will obviously give more importance to the following buildup. It will highlight the remaining sounds when the rest are muted.

Building a Mix

There are two basic ways of building up a mix: from the bottom-up and from the top-down. They both refer to how you start adding tracks. In any case, the first step should be listening to all tracks,

with a lower level position for all faders, to have an idea of what will be happening in the song. You can't start one way or the other without knowing what else you will be dealing with. The names of the tracks are very important, but you also need to hear how they sound, before you temporarily mute them and start building your mix with one of the methods.

Bottom-Up Mix

A bottom-up mix starts with the foundation of the mix, the basic tracks, i.e., the rhythm section and/or low end instruments, and then moves to the higher frequency instruments, ending finally with the lead instrument or melody instrument. Probably more mixing engineers work this way than the other. The danger of this method is not leaving enough space for the leading tracks; be sure to avoid that.

Top-Down Mix

Mixing from the top down means that you start with the lead or melody instrument and work your way down to the foundation. A typical example would be this: you start with the lead vocal track, place it in its full expression, add all additional vocal tracks, and

then start adding the instrumentation. This is typical of singer/songwriter mixes, or vocal-oriented mixes. It could feel strange working that way at the beginning, but you can get used to the concept.

Rough/Static Mix

In the early stages, you'll have a "rough mix," which usually does not have automation or much attention to detail. A rough mix will be the stage when all tracks have been added and we are showing a musical and sonic idea of the song — adjusted levels and panning, with some frequency and depth treatment as well, but without much time spent on detail. It will usually be static, meaning it has no automation yet. Thus, it can also be called a "static mix."

Dynamic Mix

Once the static mix is established, you can start working on the details, including automating different parameters like levels, panning, or muting; adding more frequency or depth processing; and bringing in additional effects. This would be a "dynamic mix," where you change parameters throughout the song.

The Master Fader

Don't forget to visually monitor the master fader, the stereo bus. Every DAW or real console uses a stereo bus, which is a signal path where all channels or tracks to be mixed send their signal in order to be combined into two new outputs: Left and Right. The stereo bus receives and combines all individual track's outputs, concentrating them into this unique stereo (left and right) output signal, which is the result of the mix.

Get Started Mixing Music

There are so many variants in a mix that all the steps we cover here cannot be seen as one-at-a-time only steps. Setting levels and panning can be done simultaneously. Having basic tracks done that way, and then adding additional tracks, will probably force you to go back to the basic tracks and readjust them. It is a never-ending process of balance, initially rough, then more accurate.

Mixing can become addictive. It is challenging and enjoyable, but remember to take breaks. You could get so much into the details that it is easy to lose perspective of the big picture, the music, the

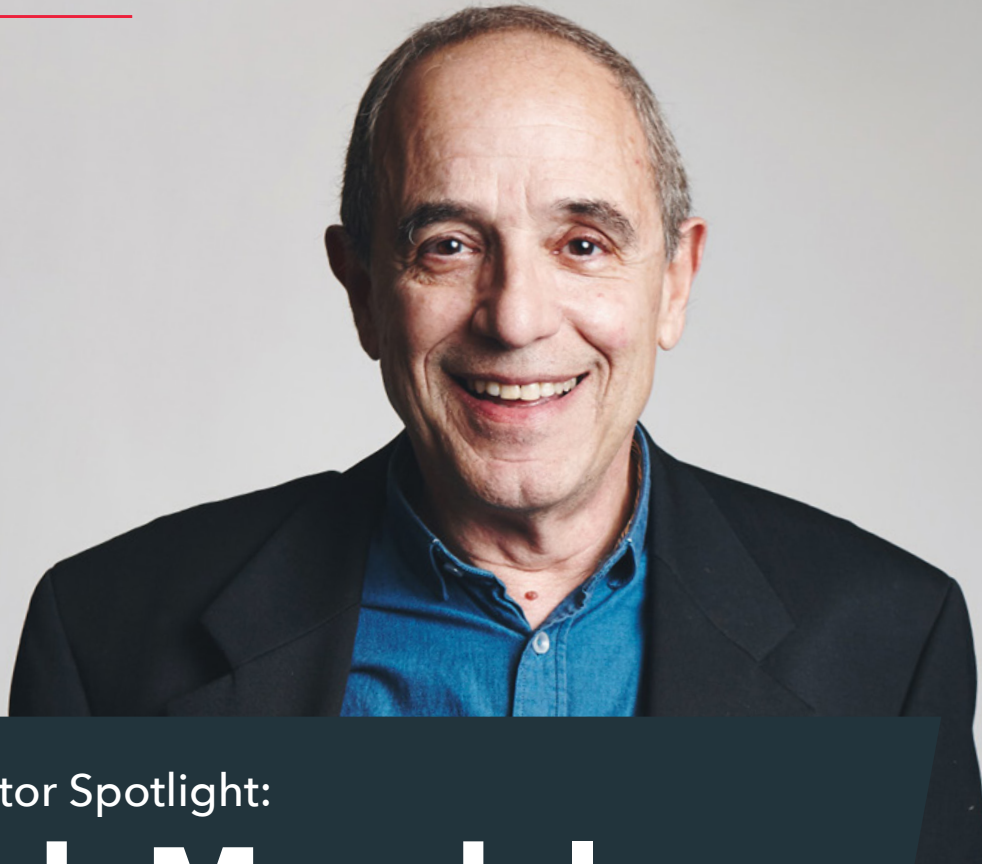
message of the song you are mixing. Leaving the work to be checked after a coffee break or on the following day will give you fresh ears to hear the result of your work as a whole. Asking opinions of others, or checking others' first impressions could be useful too.

Then it's time to take it to the artists and the other stakeholders to see what they think, which is another process altogether! But nobody should be in for any big surprises if you worked with the reference mixes they provided for you, and if you have done your job well.

Rich Mendelson and **Alejandro Rodriguez** are the authors of the Berklee Online course from which this lesson comes. Check out their bios on the following pages, or learn more about the other lessons in this course by clicking below.

Want to explore this course even further?

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Instructor Spotlight:

Rich Mendelson

Rich Mendelson is a senior faculty member in the Music Production and Engineering (MP&E) Department at Berklee College of Music. Rich specializes in mixing and recording. His former students include many Grammy-winning mixing and recording engineers, and his work has been featured in recordings by Rihanna, Nicole Scherzinger, Fergie, Garbage, and more.

At Berklee Online, Rich authored the courses *Advanced Mixing Techniques* and *Art of Mixing*.

When did you first realize you wanted to pursue a career in production?

I've been doing this for 45 years, so I have to think back, but I realized it when I was playing in a band and we used to make tapes at home, and they sounded pretty good. I really enjoyed the behind-the-scenes work of recording and mixing and I just had an interest in microphones and mixers.

What were you using when you first recorded your own band?

We were using two reel-to-reel quarter-inch tape decks and Shure 57 microphones. We had a Sony ECM 22P electric condenser mic that ran on batteries. It was 100 bucks, which back then was something.

Who was the first act that you worked with that made you realize that you were at a higher level?

An artist named Andy Pratt, who at that time had a hit record called "Avenging Annie." He was signing to Atlantic Records, and was produced by Arif Martin, who produced everyone from Chaka Khan, Norah Jones, the Young Rascals, the Bee Gees; everybody.



Instructor Spotlight:

Alejandro Rodriguez

Alejandro Rodriguez has worked with artists such as Mariah Carey, Compay Segundo, Eliades Ochoa and AfroCuban All Stars (from Buena Vista Social Club), and many more. Prior to Berklee, he was a staff engineer for EGREM Studios in Havana, Cuba.

At Berklee Online, Alejandro has co-authored *Art of Mixing*, and teaches *Critical Listening 1* and *Microphone Techniques*.

When did you first realize you wanted to work in music?

I studied classical music and at some moment I realized I wasn't going to "make it" as a classical pianist and I couldn't live without music. I had the opportunity to visit a professional studio regularly at high school age, and that set my focus towards this profession.

What is your home studio setup like?

I am a Pro Tools user more than anything else, so, PT Ultimate, running on a MacBook Pro, also Logic as a secondary DAW. I am also a live sound engineer, so I own several DPA mics and I regularly use a tube AKG mic at home, a USB based MIDI controller, many plug-ins, UA Apollo 8 audio interface, Event Tune Ref 8 speakers, different headphones, etc.

You have so many skills—recording, editing, mixing, mastering, live sound, producing—which do you use most?

I can't say only one. I work full time as a professor in the Music Production and Engineering department at Berklee (Boston campus). Outside of that, I do studio work that includes all the above, live sound—mostly as front-of-house engineer, sometimes as both front-of-house and monitors, live recording and mixing for live streaming, producing my own projects, etc.



Instructor Interview

'My First Instrument Is a DAW'

By Pat Healy

Renato Milone is a multi-instrumentalist, music producer, sound engineer, performer, and educator. After graduating from Berklee, he started The Boom House Productions with his wife, Monica Cohen. He is currently a faculty member in the Contemporary Writing and

Production department at Berklee College of Music, and along with Chrissy Tignor and Loudon Stearns, developed the Songwriting and Producing Music major at Berklee Online. In this interview he discusses finding his feet on analog equipment, and coming of age during the digital revolution.

How did the Songwriting and Producing Music major come to be?

With Chrissy, there has always been a synergy, and I'm an innovator. I need to change things, wherever I go. So we were trying to take the best of CWP and the best of Songwriting and put that experience together and create something beautiful that would be a little more technical than only Songwriting, and a little more expressive than only CWP, basically.

I've read that you've been producing and composing since your dad bought you a Philips double tape recorder at the age of seven. If that's not a perfect origin story for this dual discipline, then I don't know what it is.

I had two cassettes and I would put the first one in, record something, then move it from this place to the other place. And I was able to record something on top of whatever I just

recorded, which was multi-tracking, and I didn't know. And so while my friends were going out and playing ball, I was inside, just overdubbing myself.

So I'm doing the math and you're just about old enough that you're not a DAW native. And I'm guessing a lot of your students are.

That's the thing. It's funny because I was a student at Berklee, and I now teach with all of my teachers. So when I got to Berklee, I was learning from this generation of teachers who now are my colleagues. And they assume I'm a millennial, which technically I'm not. I'm right on the edge, but at the same time I lived the digital revolution. When I started I was doing things with knobs. I still have some here. And I like the knobs. I love them! And I feel right at home when coming back. I see people buying gear again. What's vintage for them is how I trained. Once in one of the CWP projects, we went down to the studio. We went inside—and we have a whole bunch of vintage gear—and one of my students pointed at a compressor, and he said, “Wow, they just made a hardware version of that Logic plug-in.” I was like, “Oh my God, I'm old. I'm very old.”

Learning production on analog equipment first, was that something you've been able to leverage in other areas?

Yeah. Especially now, since they make these visual interfaces that remind you of the older gear. I feel right at home. So it was an amazing training being able to do that. I talk with my students a lot about cuts in EQ and they ask me why. And I'm like, "Well, because if you add frequencies, you add noise." . . . It's a little bit like training with an older, rusty bike, and then they give you a racing bike.



For me, recording is the process of composing. There is no difference.

- Renato Milone

So when I jump on Logic, now I'm really fast and I can do stuff. But I remember back in the days I had to call all my friends to make up a mixer because they were my automations. We were, "When this part happens in the song, move this. When this other part happens, move that." And now you can just do it yourself, which is better.

As far as songwriting goes, how often do you record in your DAW as a way of composing, and how often do you compose outside of the recording process?

I would say my first instrument is a DAW. It's Logic. The historic image of a singer/songwriter is this person that has a guitar and they just write about how broken their heart is or something like that. I do that with Logic! So for me, recording is the process of composing. There is no difference.

Another way to ask that is "how often do you find yourself still writing a composition while you're in the recording process?"

That's all I do. The way I teach is this: back in the days before the computer was so advanced, production and the making of a record had one timeline that went in one direction. You do one thing then you move to the next, then you move to the one after that, and so on. It's a chain. Now these things are like a *Stargate/Back to the Future* kind of thing, where you write something, then you mix it, then you edit, then you write it again. So you jump in time and there is no "one" direction. That's how I mostly see myself doing things basically. Especially when it's for myself, like when I'm creating.

That was my next question: Which fulfills you more, writing your own song or producing somebody else's?

When you produce somebody else's, you have to be part of a team. You have a role and you're going to have to play it. It can be a multidisciplinary role, which means that you're basically maybe writing the song, then you're mixing it. . . . Usually I advise my students to have a timeframe, in which you're doing all those activities. Otherwise, you're going to find yourself being in this project forever and it doesn't matter how much money they're giving you, because it's never worth it. When it's for myself, I can never really put an end to it because I enjoy the process as much as the outcome. So I can stay there and move that knob forever!

What is your process when doing work for the company you founded, The Boom House?

The Boom House is me and my wife. We started as a company to create music for visuals, and it's so funny because we were able to compete with big, big companies in New York City doing stuff for TV, just because we were good at networking. The competition had studios and they had their equipment and we had one camera, one interface, a couple of mics, and my computer. That's it! And yet because of that, our prices were much more competitive. And also

we were the creative alternative. And we were right in the right spot when it came to trend, so we would read the needs of the market in terms of aesthetics. And now The Boom House Productions is slightly more towards video, as my wife really became a filmmaker. She's got a couple of big films going around in festivals right now.

You mentioned how you had one interface. What is the bare minimum a songwriter should have for recording? Say they're going to go record a demo and they have an empty house for the weekend. What do they need?

So I talk with a lot of older generation teachers and musicians, and they say that the recording studio is over. I don't see it that way.

The way I see it is that it has changed. It just became portable.

So nowadays I look at production as guerilla-style, where all you need to have is basically an interface, a computer, and at least one mic. That's all you need! And it's not that the studio doesn't exist anymore, it's just that now you can have that studio wherever you like—it can be the basement of your parents' house. If tomorrow I had time and money to make an album, I wouldn't go to a studio. I would rent out a villa somewhere, hire a bunch of musicians that I love to hang out with, bring my interface and my computer, and a couple of mics and record my album there, because that's the future.

Selling Your Songs to the Screen

By Brad Hatfield

From the Online Course
Songwriting for Film and TV

The use of songs in visual media has changed from generation to generation. Because new technology keeps emerging, there are many new opportunities for songs to be licensed. And these opportunities will only increase as developers come up with more apps, and new forms of media continue to catch the attention of the masses.

Film

The income trail that results from a successful placement in a major motion picture is a long one. Even a small indie film will deliver some peripheral income from broadcast on TV or other broadcast technology.

Recently there has been an increase in the usage of songs in motion pictures, chipping away at the amount of underscore. I believe this is partially due to directorial artistic needs, as well as the fact that there is so much music available now for licensing. Also, soundtracks that contain the most popular songs have been quite successful, financially. There are soundtrack CDs that feature the underscore, but this is a limited market compared to soundtrack CDs that contain full songs. Also, due to streaming, this income isn't quite what it was a decade ago.

If your song is used in a major motion picture in the US, you'll negotiate licensing fees for the initial use. The fee that you are paid is for the "theatrical" release and the probable subsequent release as a DVD, download, or whatever media may exist in the future. The good news is that if the film is successful, it will also play in foreign territories, entitling you to foreign theatrical performance royalties. The next move down the income chain is to broadcast on TV. Typically, a feature film will be available first on subscription TV such as HBO, Showtime, etc., earning you performance royalties. If the film is really big, it will probably end up on network TV as well, generating more performance income. Of course, this same process will be repeated in foreign territories, so I think you get the picture: a successful placement is the gift that keeps giving!

There's even more opportunity for music placement than you might know, especially when we consider the variables related to the size and scope of the film. While the art film that you scored for your friend probably won't necessitate printing up sheet music to sell or children's toys that feature a snippet of your song, these needs can sometimes arise with higher-budget films. Check out the chart on the following page to see a general overview of the potential income flow that could result from a song being placed in a film.

Potential Income Flow after Placement in Film

1. Initial Song Placement in a Feature Film

Sync license fees paid to writer(s), publisher(s), master owner(s) covers:

- A.** US Theatrical Release
 - B.** DVD/Download Release
 - C.** CD Soundtrack Release
- (Mechanical Licensing Fees paid per unit sold/downloaded)

2. Performance Royalties

- A.** Foreign Theatrical Release
- B.** US and Foreign Subscription Broadcast Television
(HBO, Showtime, Cinemax, etc.)
- C.** Radio Airplay - Foreign and Domestic
- D.** US & Foreign Network TV Broadcast Television
- E.** Stage Shows Based on the Film

3. Print Rights - Sheet Music

4. Mechanical Fees - Toys

5. Cover Songs, etc.

Clearly, there are many ways that your song could generate income if used in a film—maybe some you weren't even aware of!

Television

The use of songs in network television series as a dramatic tool and atmosphere creator is on the rise. Even if a song is not the most prominent part of a scene, there are many types of song usages that will still earn the writer some great royalties once it is included in a show. Songs that are played in the background of a bar or café scene still need to be licensed, and if the show is successful, such a licensed song will continue to earn money for the writer as it moves through repeated broadcasts.

Television shows (as of this writing) are moving towards using “artists” as opposed to “writers” for their song needs. A show that affiliates with recognizable or even an up-and-coming artist, can add viewership based solely on this relationship. With an increase in soundtrack albums being released by shows, an artist’s name will be more of a draw as opposed to a behind-the-scenes writer. In most cases, shows are trying their best to be cutting edge, and want to avoid using common or “generic” music from music libraries and their writers.

To position yourself as a more marketable songwriter, it is advised that you maintain an artist site on SoundCloud or similar site to display your songwriting. Being a “real artist” may help you get a song placed. The income trail for your song in TV shows as opposed to film is a little shorter because you will not have the initial domestic and foreign theatrical release.

However, if the show becomes syndicated, it can still generate many years of income as it moves through foreign markets and onto channels that broadcast syndicated shows. Having one of your songs featured prominently on a popular TV series can create a buzz that will increase traffic to your online sales method: iTunes, CD Baby, Napster, Bandcamp, etc. Major artists benefit from a show informing the viewer of what song is playing by a screen crawl, or substantial mention in the closing credits. As technology advances, I’m pretty sure the content will be instantly accessible for purchase to a viewer through other means. These are exciting times to be a songwriter!

Personal Insight

I wrote several songs that were used in the popular HBO show *The Sopranos*. It was to my great surprise that when technology to view

the show on a cell phone became a reality, I had a licensing income windfall because the initial licensing did not include that method of distribution!

Animated Film

With Disney classics as the most salient examples, this medium for songs creates an unbelievable cross-marketing opportunity for soundtrack CDs (yes, actual CDs, since parents still tend to buy physical products for their kids), downloads, DVDs, ice shows, radio airplay, Broadway versions, sheet music, toys, and other merchandise. Licensing fees and royalties from many of these peripheral usages can add up to a substantial amount of income for a songwriter.

Having a song on a soundtrack CD (even if yours isn't the "hit") can earn income based on the sales of the full CD in physical form or downloads. If the animated feature is adapted to stage, ice shows, or even a live actor feature film, new opportunities will arise to have the song performed and/or recorded. And then there is always the toy that sings the song—more royalties there!

Although Disney tends to use staff writers and other well-known composers, there are many other film companies that produce animated features that utilize songs and may provide opportunities for lesser-known writers.

Video Games and Other Media

Video games have long had musical accompaniment with memorable themes and fantastic underscore. As of this writing, video game producers are licensing more songs from well-known bands as well as some new acts to include with the games. Recent studies have shown that 26 percent of the gamers are over 50 years old, and 25 percent are 18 and younger. The average game player is 33 years old and has been playing games for 12 years.

The video game songwriting landscape is a unique one, because you may be sonically challenged by the sound of explosions, racing engines, or battling robots, so the song really has to be able to keep up with that energy and keep the game player fired up! Other opportunities for having your song used in a video game might include having your song translated into Simlish for use in the Sims game. If you're not familiar with Simlish, you really owe it to

yourself to look up some of the songs online. You'll hear Katy Perry in a brand new way.

There are many other outlets in visual media for your songs, and many more outlets yet to be discovered. More than ever, entrepreneurs of all types are moving their storefront online, and often need some great music for their sites. I've had a few of my instrumental songs licensed for use on sites displaying visual artists' and photographers' works. There will forever be a use for good songs, and if you write them so they work instrumentally, as well as vocally, they will serve you well for many years.

Brad Hatfield is the author of the Berklee Online course from which this lesson comes. Learn how he got started placing music for TV on the following pages, or learn more about the other lessons in this course by clicking the link below.

Want to explore this course even further?

[Learn More](#)



Instructor Spotlight:

Brad Hatfield

Brad Hatfield is an Emmy Award–winning composer and an associate professor of Songwriting at Berklee College of Music. His musical compositions have been heard in movies such as *Borat*, *The Break-Up*, and *Iron Man 2*, and on television series such as *The Sopranos*, *This Is Us*, and *The Big Bang Theory*, among many others.

At Berklee Online, Brad teaches *Music Supervision 1* and *2* and *Songwriting for Film and TV*.

What's one piece of songwriting advice that you have held onto throughout your career?

For film and TV, simple almost always wins. Clear melodies that can be sung can also be played by instruments.

What was the first song you ever placed in a TV episode?

The first vocal song was a co-write that I did with Crit Harmon called “Lose Control.” It was a dance song that was used in a *Melrose Place* episode in 1997, then was used in a few other shows and films.

What do you look for in a songwriting collaborator?

Someone who can fill my weak areas with their strengths. For me personally, I am a music person, so I tend to collaborate with lyricists.

Do you have a set process for songwriting, or does it vary from song to song?

I'm either melodically or groove driven. For film/TV source music, genre dictates the starting point. If it's an old school “American Songbook” style song, then melody always dominates. If it's a smooth jazz style song, then groove and harmony might start things off.



Instructor Interview

A Close Encounter with Counterpoint

By Jonathan Feist

Beth Denisch teaches counterpoint both at Berklee Online and at Berklee's Boston campus. Counterpoint is one of the core subjects for anyone who creates music, and while some of the ways it is used have evolved over time, many of the basic contrapuntal principles

remain as relevant today as they were centuries ago. Beth's book *Contemporary Counterpoint: Theory & Application*, published by Berklee Press, presents the practical considerations for how to use and consider counterpoint in today's musical industry, whether you are writing rock songs, film scores, EDM tracks, or any type of music. She discusses all of this and more below.

What is counterpoint?

Counterpoint is two or more independent melodic lines working together to create music. This creates a polyphonic texture.

Music made mostly of chords creates a homophonic texture and a piece for solo flute makes monophony. It is a collection of musical techniques, and polyphony is a texture that music using counterpoint creates.

Why is counterpoint such a standard part of music education?

Composers develop many different skills for their toolbox. These include competencies in the rhythmic and pitch idioms common to their style choices. More than offering skill competency in the traditional contrapuntal styles, the technique provides a way of looking at writing music that can be applied to many different styles.

How can studying counterpoint improve your music?

Counterpoint's power and effectiveness as a creative technique provides musicians with the technical skills to more fully realize their musical ideas. Techniques fuel inspiration, and a well-equipped composer transforms that creative spark into an effective piece of music by using the tools of the craft.



Techniques fuel inspiration, and a well-equipped composer transforms that creative spark into an effective piece of music.

- Beth Denisch

Is traditional “species counterpoint” still relevant to contemporary music?

“Species counterpoint” is a specific pedagogy that has been used for centuries. It presents the basic elements of counterpoint in graduated exercises to produce competency in that historical style period.

What's new about counterpoint in contemporary styles, compared to how voices related to each other in classical music?

Traditionally, counterpoint was inseparable from the species pedagogy. Now, it can be taught as a collection of techniques applicable to many different styles of music both historic and contemporary.

For performers, rather than composers, what are the benefits of understanding counterpoint?

Performers in many contemporary idioms apply some level of improvisation in their music making from ornamentation and re-melodizing a pop vocal line to soloing over in an extended developmental manner as in jazz. Across this application of “making it your own,” contrapuntal techniques offer practical resources with which to manipulate one’s chosen musical parameters.

Counterpoint helps us musicians more fully respect our musical ideas by enhancing our understanding of how these ideas can be revisited and transformed.

Can you share some favorite examples, both in a classical style and then in a contemporary one?

Yes, first, from the Classical/Baroque era, we have Barbara Stozzi's "Canto di bella bocca." Listen for the two vocal lines working together to create an overall sound while each voice also maintains its melodic independence. Then the other one is in a contemporary pop/neo-soul style: "Floetic" (Marsha Ambrosius, Natalie Stewart, and Floetry). Listen to the intertwining of the ostinatos, samples, synthesized melodic lines, and vocal melodic lines: both sung and spoken/chanted. The primary texture of this composition is polyphonic. The continually moving lines direct the listener to a linear rather than vertical focus.

World-Class Courses

With Berklee Online, you have more than 200 courses to choose from, including dozens of songwriting and music production courses. Here's a look at some selected offerings:

- **Collaborative Songwriting** [↗](#)
- **Music Production 101** [↗](#)
- **Songwriting: Melody** [↗](#)
- **Ableton Live Fundamentals** [↗](#)
- **Commercial Songwriting Techniques** [↗](#)
- **Art of Mixing** [↗](#)





Instructor Spotlight:

Prince Charles Alexander

Prince Charles Alexander is a music producer and audio engineer whose clients include Mary J. Blige, the Notorious B.I.G., Usher, Aretha Franklin, P. Diddy, and others. He has garnered more than 40 Platinum and Gold certifications and has multiple Grammys.

At Berklee Online, Prince Charles is the author of several production and songwriting courses.

Do you have a favorite vocal effect to use in the studio?

My favorite vocal effect is reverb. It's like salt and pepper: not enough and there is no flavor. Too much and the meal is ruined, but when seasoned properly, the meal (song) is exquisite.

Who is a singer whose vocal qualities you most admire?

Marvin Gaye is my all-time favorite because he had multiple vocal textures and timbres; and, as a vocal producer, more or less invented a multi-track vocal style that most record producers draw from to this day.

You've engineered and produced so many people and you've learned from so much experience. Are you still learning?

I went back in 2012 to get my master's degree in music entrepreneurship and I graduated in 2014, 35 years after I got my bachelor's degree. . . . But yeah, the three tiers of it were creativity, technology, and business. The creativity was the first part of my life. The technology was the second part of my musical journey, and then the business is the third part of it. So I'm trying to show a generation of musical people that our instrument is not the be-all-and-end-all of who we are as human beings and our ability to connect to people.

Music Publishing: Picking Hit Songs

By Eric Beall

From the Online Course
Music Publishing 101

If you're a songwriter, congratulations! You're also a publisher. You become one the moment you write your first song. Music publishing is one of the most promising areas for growth in today's music business because it reaches across so many different products, services, and media. Anywhere music is being used in the world, there is a music publisher involved and profiting from that use.

Likewise, whatever sector of the music business you happen to be in, whether you're a songwriter, a performer, a booking agent, a record label owner, a DJ, a radio programmer, or a recording engineer, it's possible to add a music publishing component to your business. In order to do that, you must become familiar with the process of hearing music critically and objectively to predict its commercial success.

Be a Great Critic (To Yourself and Others)

No artist likes a critic. This means that trying to provide songwriters with an honest appraisal of their work is rarely a simple task. It's even less simple if you inhabit both roles at the same time—creator

of the song, as well as the critical voice of reality. Not an easy gig. The problem with most critics is that it is too easy to be a “judge”—criticism can too quickly become a thumbs-up or thumbs-down, make-it-or-break-it proposition. But if your goal is to develop your songwriter or the song in question, that sort of black/white, yes/no judgment will not be helpful.

The question for a critical publisher should not be, “Do I like the song?” The question should be, “What are the song’s strengths and weaknesses, and how can it be improved?” That means taking an approach that’s constructive; your critique should be specific and done from a commercial point of view.

The first step in the critique process is to break the song into individual components. This is tricky because many songs succeed largely on the strength of one element: a great track that covers up a lack of melody or a great melody that lifts a mediocre lyric. But it’s important to assess the song’s strengths and weaknesses in a very specific way: melody, lyric, structure, or groove. Figure out what’s good in the song, what’s just okay, and what needs to be fixed. You might also be able to point to something that the song is missing. Does it need an instrumental hook? A bridge? Something else?

Songwriting is an Art, Publishing is a Business

As a publisher, your role is to maximize the commercial potential of the song. When you consider the tempo of the song, keep in mind that there's much greater demand for midtempo or uptempo songs than there is for slow ballads. When you look at the lyric, consider whether it's specific to one gender and could be made more saleable with an alternate male or female version. The songwriter creates, but the publisher sells. It's up to you, the publisher, to fit the song into some commercial format, in a specific genre, for a particular audience.

While it might not seem like a terribly creative approach, the truth is that there are specific qualities common to most hit songs, and those characteristics can be the measure by which you critique a stack of new demos. A&R execs that you pitch the song to will be looking for elements like a provocative or surprising title, a strong structure with a natural build and release, or a demo production that suits a target audience. Check out the *Song Quality Checklist* on the next page—it's a great Q&A-style tool for this kind of assessment.

The Song Quality Checklist

Question	Assessment
Does the title sound like a “hit”?	Yes or No? Why?
Is there a concept for the song?	Yes or No? Why?
Is the lyric effective? Appropriate? Convincing? Singable? Appealing? Cliché-free?	Yes or No?
Is the song structured correctly? Is there a natural build and release within the song structure?	Yes or No?
Does the arrangement serve the song? Does it enhance the song?	Yes or No? Why?
Is the tempo right? Does the song drag?	Yes or No? Why?
Is the demo’s production “dynamic” and “in your face”?	Yes or No? Why?
Does the demo fit clearly into one specific genre? Is that the appropriate genre for the song?	Yes or No? Why?
Does the song have the potential for mass appeal? Is it the right length?	Yes or No? Why?

Naturally, the *Song Quality Checklist* is neither exhaustive nor infallible. There are exceptions to every rule, as this is an art, not a science. The real value of the checklist is to direct your attention to specific aspects of the song, and to bring out the song's strengths and weaknesses. It will help you avoid make-it-or-break-it judgments. Instead, it will focus your songwriter on specific elements that are working effectively or areas in need of improvement.

This is important, especially if the song you're considering is not something you wrote. When you're critiquing other writers' work, formulating your opinion and developing your ideas of how to improve the song is only half the battle. You still have the formidable challenge of sharing your thoughts with the songwriter in a way that is honest and persuasive, but also encouraging rather than confidence-shattering. Never forget that you and your writer are on the same team. Just as coaches can't afford to demoralize their players, you must develop your songwriter without discouraging them.

The chart on the next page can help you translate your vague (and potentially insulting) comments into a more constructive critique.

Vague vs. Specific Critique

Vague	Specific
"I'm just not feeling it."	"The song's concept is not provocative or strong enough — it's not something that will make an audience react."
"I don't know what to do with it."	"It doesn't fit clearly into a specific radio format or market. Maybe we need to focus the demo production in a more obvious direction."
"It's cool, but it's not a hit."	"The tempo is too slow and the lyric is too vague and undefining to be a first single. This feels like an album track, which isn't what the project needs."
"That drum sound sucks."	"The snare feels a little dated and it's not cutting through the mix. We need something closer to the sound on the artist's current single."

Your relationship as a publisher to a songwriter is not much different than a book editor to an author or a director to an actor. Because you have the vantage point of being on the outside of the song and seeing how it fits commercially into the marketplace, you

have to bring that perspective to your writers and help them hone and polish their craft.

If you are playing the role of both publisher and writer, your role as critic becomes important to your very survival. Nothing will damage a songwriter-owned publishing company more than a lack of quality control.

If A&R people sense that you are not making the hard judgments about your music, they will quickly classify your company as a vanity project and relegate you to the do-not-call list. On the other hand, if you can learn to be objective about your own material, you'll not only become a better publisher—you'll become a better songwriter as well.

Try It Out

Find an audio file of one song from your publishing catalog. If that's not possible, use a song that you don't publish. This could be something from a friend or even something off an album. But try to use something relatively unknown. Analyze the song you've selected, using the *Song Quality Checklist*. What could you do to improve it?

No one ever enters the music publishing business fully prepared. Even well-funded startup ventures often open their doors before their administration systems or sub-publishing relationships are fully developed. Obviously, every new music catalog is a work in progress. You can't wait forever to start getting your music out there. At the same time, the process of critique that is at the heart of "getting the music right" cannot be rushed or skipped over. So remember to share your thoughts with the songwriter in a way that's honest, but also encouraging rather than negative. If you can learn to be objective about your own material, and others', you'll not only become a better publisher—you'll become a better songwriter.

Eric Beall is the author of the Berklee Online course from which this lesson comes. Read about his experience in the music industry on the following pages, or learn more about the other lessons in this course by clicking the link below.

Want to explore this course even further?

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Instructor Spotlight:

Eric Beall

Eric Beall is the vice president of A&R at Shapiro Bernstein, one of the industry's most respected independent music publishers. Beall has also held senior creative posts at Zomba Music, Jive Records, and Sony/ATV Music. He has directed writers in the development of material for artists like Backstreet Boys, *NSYNC, and Britney Spears.

At Berklee Online, Eric authored the course *Music Publishing 101*, providing a step-by-step guide to setting up your own music publishing company.

How did you first become aware of what music publishing was?

I first learned about music publishing as a songwriter. At the time, I wasn't very clear on the function of a music publisher, but I did know people who were doing publishing deals and getting some advance money in exchange, which definitely grabbed my interest.

You coordinated and directed writers in the development of material for Jive Records superstars like Backstreet Boys, *NSYNC, and Britney Spears. What is your proudest moment from that stage of your career?

My proudest moment was working with our songwriters in New York, Nashville, LA, and London and managing to get their songs on the albums of those acts—which were some of the biggest of that decade.

Are you still able to make time for music that has nothing to do with your participation on the business side?

I try to be available to young songwriters with advice and assistance, so I'm always involved with a lot of music that I don't necessarily have signed to my company. Most of my focus now is helping new artists and writers find their career path.



Student Stories

From Student to Working Producer

By Talia Smith

Katie Day is a Berklee alum and a fourth-generation Chicago Cubs fan. In 2015, she set her love for the team to words and music, writing two songs to coincide with Cubs' promising season. Katie's songs eventually landed in the inbox of an ESPN reporter, who sent

them to the DJ at Wrigley Field. The following year, Katie's songs became the victory anthems for the Cubs' 2016 World Series win, their first World Series win in a century.

"I grew up loving this team so much and it seemed impossible for them to ever overcome defeat and finally win," says Katie. "And then when they did, it really did feel like anything was possible."

Katie's songs proved that she could elevate a brand with her compositions, and gave her the confidence to start writing music for advertising. In 2017, she enrolled in Peter Bell's *Writing and Producing Advertising Music* course through Berklee Online. A year later, she happily reported back to Bell that she started her own music production house, Shortcake Music. The work that Katie has done with Shortcake has since been featured in commercials by Dove, *The Sims*, and Arizona State University, among many others.

"I was struck immediately by her positive energy and her talent," says Bell, who has earned two Emmy awards, recorded with Bonnie Raitt, and composed theme music for shows like *This Old House*. Katie and Bell have an ongoing email chain that dates back multiple years.

Katie honed her production and music biz chops right out of high school as a Berklee campus student. By the time she enrolled in Bell's online course, she had spent a decade working as a musician between Nashville and Los Angeles. She could write and produce a catchy track, no problem, but needed ad industry know-how.



The good thing about the work that I'm doing now is that I get to be in the studio, making music all the time.

- Katie Day

“The class covered everything from the music-making to industry standards, in terms of what you're going to be submitting, what format, and how to deal with the industry people in contract and what's expected in terms of quality,” she says. “Learning all of that basically gave me the confidence to really do it.”

After the course, Katie and Kyle Vandekerkhoff—a fellow Berklee

alum and sound engineer—collaborated to make the company official, bringing in an engineer and composer. With a few projects on deck, they covered their initial setup costs. And to acquire more clients, Katie pulled from her contacts, reaching out to people who she knew worked in advertising, but hadn't talked to in years. One client came from reaching out to someone she played softball with eight years prior.

“You have to approach all of your relationships maturely because you never know where things are going to lead,” says Katie. “You might have to deal with people who you don't think are going to come back into your life, five or 10 years down the road. ... Somebody might recommend you just because they think you would be easy to work with.”

Her networking and cold-calling paid off. Katie acquired a number of clients after pitching her services to agencies in New York, San Francisco, and London.

Writing music for advertising has allowed Katie to take control of her work and make a living doing what she loves: making music. She remembers the frustration of licensing deals and the mystery

of where her music would end up. Now she plays an active role in who uses her music.

“The good thing about the work that I’m doing now is that I get to be in the studio, making music all the time, and I don’t have to pay to do it,” says Katie. “I’m getting paid to record. I had a couple of licensing deals when I was an artist and I don’t even know what they did. It was like a wall and I never got to know what was going on on the other side. Now I get to be on that side of it and I get to actually pitch the music and see people’s reactions.”

For other musicians interested in making the leap into writing music for advertising or starting their own music house, Katie suggests just taking the plunge, because there’s always going to be a reason to put it off.

“Just jump in,” she says. “All of this resulted from me putting myself in uncomfortable situations. You learn as you go and you get better at it. If you’re nice to people, good things can happen if you just put yourself out there.”

Your Career Path

Ever wonder what kinds of careers exist in songwriting and music production? There's much more to it than just producing your own songs. Potential opportunities include:

Recording Engineer • Sound Effects Editor • Acoustical Consultant • Top-Line Songwriter • Musical Theater Adapter Studio Manager • Mastering Engineer • and more!

Check out our Careers page for more inspiration!

[Learn More](#)





Instructor Spotlight:

Erin Barra

Erin Barra is a songwriter, educator, producer, multi-instrumentalist, and music technology consultant. She is a leading product specialist for Ableton and works with artists and bands to integrate digital technologies into their writing, production, and stage setups. Erin has worked with Grammy winners like John Oates, George Massenburg, Kathy Mattea, and Elliot Scheiner.

At Berklee Online, Erin has authored numerous courses about songwriting and production.

What is your guiding principle as a producer?

Use your ears—plain and simple. People get stuck because they're not truly listening or their ears aren't open enough yet to make proper assessments and decisions based upon what they're hearing. Any producer's real instrument is their ears and the six inches that lie between them, so you need to learn how to properly use them.

What's one piece of songwriting advice you've held onto throughout your career?

Be economical with your lyric writing—a few words can say a lot.

You've authored and co-authored many courses on Ableton. How did you first become interested in electronic music?

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